
Paper 2, Option 2E.2:

The German Democratic Republic, 1949–90

Overview

This option comprises a study in depth of the creation, development, decline and collapse of the communist East German state, 1949–90. For the whole of its existence, East Germany was a key focus of world attention as it lay on the frontline of the Cold War, where contrasts between East and West could be seen at their starkest.

Students will gain an in-depth understanding of the political, economic and social policies of the East German government in this period, and their effects on the lives of its people.

Key topics	Content
1 Establishing and consolidating communist rule in the GDR, c1949–61	• The post-war division of Germany; the Soviet zone; creation of the Socialist Unity Party (SED) 1946; growing divisions among the victor powers; formation of the GDR 1949. • The system of government: the head of state; the <i>Volkskammer</i>; the <i>Länderkammer</i>; the dominance of the SED and its General Secretary, Ulbricht. • Economic developments, 1949–61: the USSR's seizure of reparations from 1945; socialist economics and planning; industrial developments; agricultural collectivisation; opposition to socialist economics. The rising of June 1953. The impact of socialist economics on the GDR. • Defending the GDR, 1949–61: emigration in the 1950s and its impact on the country; reasons for the crisis of 1960–61; the building of the Berlin Wall and its importance; the influence of Khrushchev.
2 The development of the East German state, 1961–85	• Economic situation after 1961: the end of mass emigration; the New Economic System, 1963–68 and the Economic System of Socialism, 1968–71; increased economic production, including consumer goods; membership of COMECON and its importance. • Honecker and the development of a GDR identity; mass media; the importance of sport, especially Olympic successes and women's sports. • Relations with West Germany: <i>Ostpolitik</i>; the agreements of 1970–72; the relaxation of travel restrictions and the growth of communications with the Federal Republic. The impact of <i>Ostpolitik</i> on the GDR's economy and standard of living.

Key topics	Content
3 Life in East Germany, 1949–85	• Social change and welfare programmes: housing; education; the changing status and role of women; the development of an extensive social welfare programme. • Repression and control: the Ministry of State Security (the Stasi), its methods and activities; control of young people through the Free German Youth (FDJ); propaganda and censorship. Extent of popular support for the GDR. • The SED and the Protestant church: attacks on religious beliefs and practices; education and Protestant youth groups; the establishment of a dialogue between church and state. • Western influences on the GDR, including the impact of <i>Ostpolitik</i> on travel between the two German states; the influence of radio, television, films and popular music.
4 Growing crises and the collapse of communist rule in the GDR	• Economic situation in the 1980s: the growing national debt; high spending on health and welfare; the poor quality of consumer and other goods; economic relations with West Germany. • Gorbachev's influence: the impact of <i>perestroika</i> and <i>glasnost</i> on the GDR's government and people. The pressure for reform; the role of Protestant opposition groups; the declining authority of the SED government. • The events of 1989, including the opening of Hungary's border with Austria, emigration from the GDR, Gorbachev's visit to East Berlin in October, the decline of Honecker's influence and his dismissal, Krenz and the opening of the Berlin Wall. • The end of the GDR, 1989-90: the collapse of the SED government 1989 and the elections of March 1990; the reunification of East and West Germany, March–October 1990; the attitudes of Kohl, Britain, the USA and the USSR; the accession of the eastern territories to West Germany.

Route F: Searching for rights and freedoms in the twentieth century

Overview

Students taking Route F will study:

- *Paper 1, Option 1F: In search of the American Dream: the USA, 1917–96*

and **either**:

- *Paper 2, Option 2F.1: India, c1914–48: the road to independence*

or:

- *Paper 2, Option 2F.2: South Africa, 1948–94: from apartheid state to 'rainbow nation'.*

The options in Route F are linked by the common theme of a search for rights, freedoms and greater equality during the twentieth century. In the USA, the quest for political, social and economic advancement looked mainly to reform existing structures. In India and South Africa, this quest led to more radical outcomes, bringing an end to imperial rule in India and the apartheid regime in South Africa.

Studying two different countries allows students to develop a greater understanding of both similarities and differences in the search for greater rights, freedoms and equality in the twentieth century world (although students will not be required to answer comparative questions that link the breadth and the chosen depth option).